



A KALEIDOSCOPE of fans and nations have come together in L.A. for World Cup matches at SoFi Stadium. KELVIN KUO Los Angeles Times

Soccer fans are united, defying skeptics

Amid political unease in U.S., diverse locals and visitors bond over World Cup in L.A.

By CLARA HARTER

The run-up to the World Cup in Los Angeles was marked by anxiety over how immigration enforcement, travel restrictions and anti-Trump backlash would affect the spirit and attendance of the games.

But on the streets of L.A. over the last week, something very different has happened.

Fans from a kaleidoscope of cultural backgrounds have come together to act out the kind of world — and city — they want to live in.

On the shuttle bus from downtown to Inglewood on Monday, there were scores of people with Farsi-embellished shirts and crowds of grinning Kiwis as one would expect for the Iran-versus-New Zealand showdown that evening. However, there were also clusters of striped blue Argentina T-shirts, plenty of Team USA jerseys, and a loud group of fans chanting “Viva Mexico” from the back of the bus.

Similar scenes played out on the Metro K Line as World Cup-goers from all over traded stories of how they scored tickets, tips for navigating L.A.’s transit system, and wistful memories of tournaments past.

“This festival is about unity and bringing the whole world together; there are 48 nations and everybody is having a good time,” said Ardy Salem, an Iranian American dentist who traveled from the Bay Area to attend the game, as he surveyed the crowd outside SoFi Stadium on Monday with unabashed glee.

“Just for a moment,” he said, “we get to leave all the politics behind.”

David Leon, 32, of Watts [See Joy, A6]

FBI fights drone threat at World Cup venues

Scores of pilots cited amid elevated terror fears

By Richard Winton

As World Cup soccer fans cheer for their teams in Los Angeles and stadiums across the nation, FBI agents are working in command centers, watching out for unauthorized flying objects.

It’s a nerve-racking race against time, and one week into the World Cup, the counter-unmanned aircraft centers have been busy.

“We have a short period of time to determine if it is a threat,” said FBI Special Agent James Peaco, the weapons of mass destruction and counter-unmanned aircraft system coordinator for the bureau’s Los Angeles office, who is overseeing counter-drone operations. “The drone threat is here, and it is real.”

The FBI has cited scores of drone pi-

lots for interference in World Cup games, though a precise national total was not available. Their names have not been released, and law enforcement sources said they were hobbyists who do not appear to be intent on causing harm.

In the last week in Inglewood, where New Zealand and Iran have faced off and so have the Americans versus Paraguay, the FBI said it has intercepted at least 28 drones around SoFi Stadium and the fan festival at the L.A. Coliseum.

Some drone operators are spotted by the federal eyes in the skies, but most commonly, ground interception teams of the FBI and local law enforcement at each venue make physical contact with the drone pilot. [See Drones, A6]



A 2023 poll found that 77% of principals had taken recess away as a punishment. GENARO MOLINA Los Angeles Times

How recess debate plays out

Schools often cut the break to punish kids, boost scores. That could harm learning.

By CIERRA MORGAN

At 10:30 a.m., the bell rings through the halls of William F. Prisk Elementary School in Long Beach, sending students racing onto the playground, throwing basketballs, doing cartwheels, gliding down slides.

Recess could very well be

the most important 30 minutes of their school day for learning — and it has become a contested period for the nation’s youngest students. Teachers use it as a behavioral bargaining chip, administrators weigh playtime against sagging test scores and researchers argue over how best to structure the minutes.

The debate over recess has grown so confusing that recently the American Academy of Pediatrics stepped in and updated its policy statement. Play is not a reward, a privilege or

wasted learning time. It is a developmental necessity.

California made recess the law beginning in the 2023-24 school year, requiring at least 30 minutes of playtime daily for K-6 students and banning teachers and staff from taking it away as punishment. However, researchers say there is not a process to evaluate whether schools are fully adhering to the mandate.

Under the federal No Child Left Behind Act of 2001, schools faced mounting pressure to raise test [See Recess, A7]

Rubio and Vance reflect the GOP divide on Iran

Possible presidential contenders in 2028 have opposing views of interim peace deal.

By MICHAEL WILNER

WASHINGTON — Secretary of State Marco Rubio stood silent and stone-faced behind Donald Trump on Wednesday as the president joked of passing the buck if his deal with Iran, under increasingly withering criticism and scrutiny, ultimately falls apart.

The blame, Trump said, would probably fall on his vice president, JD Vance, who led the negotiations toward a memorandum of understanding with Iran and will sign the agreement this week in Switzerland — a ceremony that will generate indelible images for a politician openly considering a run for the White House.

The controversial diplomatic breakthrough poses a quandary for Vance, whose aides see Rubio as his most viable challenger for the Republican presidential nomination should the secretary choose to run.

“If it works out, I’m going to take the credit,” Trump said of the Iran deal, with

Rubio by his side.

“If it doesn’t work out, I’m blaming JD,” he joked. “You better be careful, JD!”

Rubio, who also serves as the president’s national security advisor, essentially has remained mum since news of a preliminary peace deal was announced by the administration on Sunday.

His absence has drawn notice across foreign policy circles — not only because Rubio has served as chief architect of the administration’s global strategy thus far, but also because he has become one of the president’s most effective communicators, both at home and abroad.

By contrast, Vance, on a scheduled press tour promoting his new book, has emerged as the face of an agreement that appears to be fracturing a Republican Party already divided over America’s role in the world.

The administration’s in- [See Iran, A5]

Details of interim pact are revealed

President Trump praises the deal to restore the prewar status quo but also opens the door to abandoning it. **WORLD, A2**

Course correction on criminal justice

Lawmakers seek limits on prison diversion for mentally ill, citing threat to public safety.

By JAMES QUEALLY

A bill to tighten California’s rules on mental health diversion — a process that allows certain criminal defendants to avoid prison for arrests linked to mental illness — is now on the verge of being signed into law by Gov. Gavin Newsom.

Assembly Bill 46, authored by Stephanie Nguyen (D-Elk Grove), gives judges much wider discretion to decide whether a defendant should be eligible for diversion. Under the current law, judges must presume mental illness was a factor if a defendant with a legitimate diagnosis seeks diversion. In order to defeat a diversion request, the burden is on prosecutors to prove mental health issues were not a factor in the alleged crime.

The new measure — which moved through the state Senate with no opposition last month and is expected to clear the reconciliation process in the Assembly this week — also gives

judges more latitude to block diversion if a defendant poses “a risk of danger to public safety,” as opposed to the higher “unreasonable risk” standard that was passed in 2018. Defendants charged with attempted murder will no longer be eligible for diversion under the new bill.

Proponents of more inclusive diversion policies argue that many people with mental health issues are locked up in California prisons and jails, where they are unable to receive the help they need.

The pending bill’s supporters say its changes are designed to address cases like that of Gilberto Gutierrez, a Los Angeles County man who has been accused of attacking his wife four times over the last 12 years.

In 2014, a misdemeanor domestic violence allegation landed Gutierrez on probation. Three years later, Gutierrez was ordered to take anger management classes after prosecutors brought felony domestic violence charges against him. Last February, prosecutors allege, he carried out a “brutal attack” on his wife with a glass bottle, leaving her with “extensive injuries,” according to [See Offramp, A7]

Fed leaves key rate intact, for now
In an unexpected outcome, nearly half of its officials signaled support for hikes later this year. **NATION, A7**

Black student program saved
LAUSD’s budget proposal would cut jobs but restore funding to a popular achievement plan. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Big expectations for ‘Toy Story 5’
Thirty years and \$3 billion later, Woody and the gang are still among Disney’s surest box office bets. **BUSINESS, A9**

Weather
Clouds, then sun.
L.A. Basin: 75/62. **B6**

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JASON ARMOND Los Angeles Times
ARTIST Ozzie Juarez will join the parade.

LACMA throws party on Wilshire
David Geffen Galleries’ grand opening weekend features an Art Parade on Saturday evening. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

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Streaming films’ diversity backslide

Netflix’s ‘KPop Demon Hunters’ bucks trend of fewer actors of color in leading roles.

By ELOISE ROLLINS-FIFE

Diversity in last year’s streaming films followed the same downward trend as theatrical releases, a new study found, with the per-

centage of people of color directing, writing and leading films diminishing.

In past years, streaming was considered a more accessible outlet for early-career, female or BIPOC filmmakers, a pattern reflected in data about gender and racial representation. According to Part 2 of UCLA’s 2026 Hollywood Diversity Report, which was released Wednesday and analyzed all of the original English-lan-

guage films distributed on major streaming platforms in 2025, that trend reversed across every category studied.

The share of streaming films directed by women declined to just over 23%, the lowest it has been since 2022, when the annual study began analyzing streaming and theatrical films separately. Among those female directors, an overwhelming majority (81%) were allotted

budgets below \$20 million, while more than a quarter of the films directed by white men exceeded \$50 million.

Only about 31% of streaming films last year had Black, Indigenous and people of color directors, down 10% since 2024, when the proportion more closely reflected U.S. demographics.

“This is an industry in flux — and in reverse, espe- [See Study, A11]